mind’.[21]

They held parties for each other, and the conversation was rather less tense than before: the shah was pleased with the Hindustani banquet Humayun arranged for him, dal khuska finding particular favour; and Humayun, no doubt, was pleased and relieved at the shah’s gift of an army of 12,000 men.

The refugees might now try and win themselves a home.

~

Kamran wasn’t happy to hear the news. It was his Kabul, after all, his home, that Humayun would come to claim. Worried, Kamran sent word to Askari in Qandahar: send Akbar to Kabul. To his credit, Askari was in two minds about giving Akbar over to Kamran’s tender mercy; but Askari did little in his life to gain a reputation for courage, certainly not when it came to defying his older and greatly more forceful brother, Kamran. His timidity won over his concern and ‘in the depth of winter’, as the land was lashed with snow and icy rain, Akbar and his older sister, Bakshi Banu – two and three years old respectively – were taken out of the fort that had been their home the past year.[22] Babur’s grandchildren were to enter their grandfather’s beloved capital as hostages.

They were escorted by those three most intimate of Akbar’s early guardians, Jiji Anaka, her husband Shamsuddin, and Maham Anaka, along with a small party of attendants, all under strict instructions to keep the children’s identity secret. They were even given false names: Akbar was called ‘Mirak’, and Bakshi ‘Bicha’.

This and other stories from Akbar’s early childhood are told by Abul Fazl, who did a great deal of painstaking research, collecting testimonies, comparing interviews, slicing through the brambles of ‘contradictions and imperfections’[23] that are the historian’s lot, to produce one of the most masterful and comprehensive accounts of a man ever written by another: the *Akbarnama*. For all the achievement of his scholarship, however, Abul Fazl is rarely willing to see his subject as anything less than superhuman; a divine glow clings to his every description of Akbar, whose every word drips with a sacred nectar. It is a haze of adulation that makes it almost impossible to see Akbar as a real person, let alone a real child; but there are moments when even Abul Fazl’s pen cannot quite hide an altogether human